Husain.[39] When he heard that Humayun wasn't well, he borrowed an army from his father-in-law and marched back home.

There was no one in Kabul to stop Kamran. Its governor, Muhammad Ali Taghayi, was recovering from a hangover in a hot bath, from which he was dragged out, naked, and killed. Others loyal to Humayun were as deftly murdered, blinded or imprisoned, and Kamran was swiftly repossessed of his old throne, surrounded by followers 'like flies at the stall of a sweetmeat-seller . . . falling upon one another'.

'How have I gone and how have I come back?' the prince asked one of them, and pat came the flattering reply, 'You went in the evening and you came in the morning.'[40]

Akbar became, once again, his uncle's hostage. He wasn't yet five years old, but it is a measure of how very soon a boy could be seen as eligible for a throne that two Persian soldiers, seeing Akbar in court, thought of staging an extempore coup in his favour, then and there. There is no record that Kamran thought of, or treated, his nephew as a threat just yet but it was only a matter of time before he would.

Humayun abandoned his excursions into Turan (which was 'relieved') and returned to recover his kingdom and rescue his son.[41] Thus was laid the famous siege of Kabul, often recounted through a montage of Kamran's escalating cruelties. Gulbadan tells of how Kamran plundered Humayun's harem, and locked the women in an improvised dungeon of 'bricks, plaster and dung-cakes'. A two-year-old girl amongst them would die before the siege was done. Next, Kamran began a grisly 'negotiation' with his besiegers, threatening Humayun's chiefs with the murder of their children and the rape of their wives unless they switched sides. One man's wife was 'suspended . . . by the breasts'. Another, Babus, had his three sons, all under seven, butchered and thrown off the fort walls, and his wife given over to 'the people of the bazaar'.[42]

The imprisoned begums sent word to Humayun to stop the siege. Humayun replied with reassuring messages and gifts: 'nine sheep, seven flasks of rose-water, one of lemonade', dresses and jackets, but no promises to reconcile with his brother. The begums were right, however: things were getting out of hand, and Kamran's worst was yet to come. As the siege continued despite his ferocious demoralizing tactics, as cannonballs and